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In late February 2022, Russia invaded Ukraine in the Donbas region after months of positioning soldiers and posturing to establish dominance against the former Soviet state. Four years later, as many as 1.2 million casualties took place in the conflict and the world was forced to take sides; policy nerds have found their nirvana ever since in analyzing a foreign state's extent of involvement in the conflict (Jones and McCabe 2026). For instance, even giving Russia ballistic missiles and propping up its oil industry, which has been faltering due to widespread global sanctions since the war began, is a position on the Ukraine war and actually a strong indication of the state's priorities, domestically and internationally, economically and politically. Nothing in global politics is unintentional; every treaty, public statement, and meeting has been carefully and strategically maneuvered to maximize the positive outcome for that state. The real ask then is not just whether and why a state would send billions of dollars in aid to Ukraine but if they would do the same for Russia and to an equal extent. **Its answers are rooted in realism and self-interest: fear of being themselves invaded by Russia, a heavy reliance on the Russian energy making sanctions economically difficult, and a long history of anti-Russian sentiment that affords a state domestic support for large foreign aid to Ukraine, as examined through the policy proposals of the United States, Hungary, and Poland.**

It is rare to find a global conflict with a universal global position, but here, the messaging was almost immediate, nearly completely unified and quite intense: Russia should not be allowed to assert its control over a sovereign state. The sanctions quickly followed, even where it hurt the most, in the energy sector. This is quite commendable because Russia has a vast and (formerly) successful near-monopoly on the global oil, coal and natural gas market. As of 2021, the European Union—notably Germany, Poland, and Hungary—imported about 45% of its natural gas from Russia through a network of pipelines such as Druzhba or the Nord Stream, which was blown up in late 2022 (REPowerEU 2025). This was convenient and fairly unobjectionable until the attack on Ukraine. The resources were relatively inexpensive because of the ease of access through the pipelines, and just as an idea, it is highly possible Europeans believed (especially after the 2014 annexation of Crimea) that economic interdependence and support for Russian energy would discourage Russia from acting out further. An attack on any NATO state or NATO ally would be an attack on the “world's most powerful alliance” after all, and while this perspective of Russian hesitation has since been proven incorrect unfortunately, it cannot be denied that the loss of manpower, resources and global support has likely devastated domestic life in Russia for both the politician and citizen (Charap and Priebe 2023). Putin has done the calculus to make the war still seem of benefit to dominate the former Eastern bloc, but it cannot imaginably be an easy decision now that most Russian energy supplies have quickly lost their buyer. The E.U. has banned all Russian coal and import only 2% of Russian oil to only two member states, Hungary and Slovakia (European Union 2025). Perhaps then it comes as no surprise that both Hungary and Slovakia have backed up Russia repeatedly since 2022.

This essay will primarily consider the policy positions under now-former Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán, since he was in office for nearly all of this war. There is some hope for both Ukraine and Hungary now that new PM Peter Magyar just last week lifted his country's veto on a \$106 billion E.U. loan, allowing the money to finally reach Ukraine (Stretch 2026).

However, Magyar is still sufficiently right-wing that it is unlikely Hungary will do an about-face in this matter, and one main reason is that Hungary receives about 90% of its crude oil from Russia (Vladimirov et. al. 2026). In fact, it seems likely that Hungary reversed its veto for aid to Ukraine after the Druzhba pipeline resumed operations; Orbán had accused Zelenskyy of shutting it down (Müller and Slominski 2024). They would be in dire straits were these pipelines to cease without a proper backup plan, so Hungary chooses to favor peace talks and ceasefire deals likely as a form of self-protection against a domestic energy crisis (Pietromarchi 2026).

By and large Orbán's entire tenure was filled with opposition to both sending military aid to Ukraine through NATO and the E.U. and to Ukraine even joining the E.U (Göransson 2025). Interestingly, the latter occurred seemingly because Orbán believes Hungarian farmers would be at economic risk were the apparently superior Ukrainian agricultural industry to dominate Europe. Hungary simply cannot afford to either antagonize Russia or to risk its own economic sufficiency, as Orbán said in 2013 "it is in Hungary's basic interest to have good relations and maintain close cooperation with Russia" and respect its culture (Madlovics and Magyar 2023). Also, Hungary does meet NATO requirements for defense spending (around 2% of their GDP) but they are not really known to be a military power, so sending equipment—or men themselves, like North Korea—is not strategic for either side. Russia is unlikely to want their resources and Hungary cannot afford to lose them (Dunay 2005). This is definitely why they take a more neutral framework through methods that seems to almost play both sides. They would appeal to Russia by claiming that they do not support Ukraine, since they have vetoed aid previously and tried to block their membership in the E.U. and continue to buy Russian oil (Schmidt and Glied 2024). They can appeal to the E.U. by claiming to take the lead on peace by offering to host negotiations and eventually having agreed to send aid to Ukraine.

That said, interestingly Hungary has accepted 25,000 Ukrainian refugees and given them government support. This is likely an optics decision: Hungary can maintain international legitimacy and their economic interests by framing their action as a humanitarian issue and not a slight against Russia (Thorpe 2023). They can very easily imply to Russia that they would similarly take in Russian refugees, that they are merely against war that hurts innocent civilians. That stance would equally give them leeway in the E.U., hopefully making them more hesitant to call out Hungary on not having sanctions for Russia. Realism is the name of the game, and Hungary knows how to play it well; all moves are clearly in self-interest.

The reality is that in autocratic-leaning states like Hungary, even though it is incompatible with E.U. norms of liberal democracy, the demagogical leader like Orbán can act near-unilaterally to preserve his ideology and dissuade opponents (Madlovics and Magyar 2023). Domestically, he had been in power for 16 years and increasingly formed an authoritarian regime; he felt he did not have to be accountable to his own people. In fact, they kept on electing him, which both likely provided Orbán with an ego boost and a means to justify his actions: the people would not re-elect him if they did not agree, which fits quite well with those aforementioned norms in the European Union. Peter Magyar is clearly not on the same level as his fellow E.U. members even after ousting an autocrat, still likely keeping his own country's economic interests in mind, but there is hope that perhaps Hungary will find room for unity with Europe in the hopefully sunset years of this horrible war.

One interesting interpretation of why Russia is seizing Ukraine is that they want to re-create the Soviet Union, a Slavic ethnostate, this time under Putin's hand. To that end, there is no

reason they would not stop at Ukraine; Nazi Germany took over a significant portion of Europe and the British conquered nearly the whole world, so Russia perhaps sees Ukraine only as a first step in an all-out conquest to come. This is scary particularly for Poland, who make Hungary seem quite spineless: they fear invasion, so they have allowed Ukraine to receive almost 90% of all of its aid through its own borders (Hartsoe 2026). The president has continually offered his support for Ukraine, even saying that “today [is] Georgia, tomorrow [is] Ukraine... and then perhaps the time will come for my country, Poland!” (President of Poland 2022). The support Poland has shown for Ukraine cannot be understated; it is no easy task, while fearing Russian invasion of one’s own country, to then send aid to the country that Russia is bombing through their own borders. That is brave and commendable.

That said, as can be expected, Poland so far has only acted to protect Ukraine as a form of protecting themselves. This continues the self-interest angle we have seen in Hungary, though at least the Polish appear to be somewhat empathetic given their circumstances. In 2022, two people were killed in Poland after a random Ukrainian missile landed in their territory (Reuters 2023). Moreover, Putin has repeatedly antagonized the Polish during his tenure, calling back to the 1940s in blaming Poland for actions in World War 2 and even threatening “any country that tried to interfere in Ukraine with consequences ‘such as you have never seen in your entire history.’” (Shevchenko 2019). If Russia’s goals in Ukraine succeed, Poland is next (Sarfraz 2023). This makes the Polish’s actions in Ukraine totally clear: they must help the E.U. and United States stop Russia, to push them back from Ukraine. This will deter the Russians from moving onto Poland, and even if they manage to, Poland will have built up and maintained enough allies to get the same military support they are now giving to Ukraine. It’s quid pro quo in the finest. It is worth noting though, as a comparison point, that the Polish leader in 2022, Jarosław Kaczyński, was widely seen as authoritarian and previously allied himself with the likes of even Orbán or Le Pen of France (Kopper et. al. 2023). He was responsible for eight years of democratic backsliding, finding himself in fairly similar conditions as Orbán’s Hungary, and yet uses that legitimacy to still fight for Ukraine (Simpson 2020).

But when one thinks about the main enemies of Russia, the United States almost immediately comes to mind. The Cold War was nearly 50 years of tensions between the two world powers, from the space race to developing nuclear weapons and even these last few years in Ukraine have resumed that state of affairs. This likely explains why there is possibly no friendlier ally to Ukraine (at least pre-Trump 2.0) for the United States has sent billions in aid, particularly weapons, vehicles and other defense systems (Wozniak 2016). They have signaled that the Ukrainians should be willing to fight to resolve this conflict, and that American support is... mostly... behind them. Even for the country with the biggest military budget by far, it is admirable to continually host negotiations and work to resolve this ongoing conflict through the Obama, Biden, and both Trump presidencies. But this is once again a symbol of American interests: there is a lingering resentment of Russia from the Cold War days that has still not left, over 30 years after the U.S.S.R. collapsed (Karazanashvili 2022). Allowing Russia to grow strong again directly undermines American ideals, of democracy and capitalism in particular, and if the foreboding future comes true with a mega Russian state, America will no longer be the global 911. This scares our egotistical leaders, and it scares everyday Americans who often fearmonger about Russia too. Zelenskyy winning the war benefits the U.S. by standing up to Russia for us, while reinforcing the norm in international law of the right to sovereign territory (Charap and Priebe 2023).

The United States' mixed-message support of Ukraine across different administrations, though, is also a phenomenon worth exploring. For instance, last year Ukrainian president Zelensky visited the White House to plead for more aid in his faltering struggles against holding off Russia. President Trump and Vice President J.D. Vance outright belittled him, having questioned why he did not thank the Americans for helping before and they also blamed Ukraine's failures on Joe Biden and the previous administration. The United States has become more isolationist following the re-election of President Donald Trump, no longer finding use in global politics that does not appear to directly help the American people. Donald Trump, is of course, a Republican so he has negatively re-framed foreign aid as something proposed by his opponents in the Democrat Party. His goal has always been to project American strength, regardless of whether it is relevant, necessary or helpful. There is that pesky realism again.

State capacity is not a question for the richest country in the world, so the United States does not hesitate to provide outright military support for Ukraine. It is logical that Hungary cannot afford to antagonize Russia, to maintain its secure source of energy and appeal to its domestic highly conservative leaders. For the same reasons, Poland must prioritize its own safety and help Ukraine knowing they will find the same support from the E.U. should Russia extend Ukraine's misery to them. The Americans are an ocean away from these bombs and wars, which makes both problems almost irrelevant to us. Additionally, we get most of our oil from Canada, and the chances of a Russian attack on America are, while higher than under the Obama administration because of Trump's general demeanor, not statistically significant necessarily because of both countries' aforementioned access to nuclear weapons (U.S. Energy Information Administration). Nuclear weapons will be more emphasized later on in this essay, but making an enemy of America is not ideal for Russia, so from all angles, the U.S. can help Ukraine actually win the war—which is what they are trying to do.

Domestically, even Democrats (who typically favor more globalist policies) must exercise caution to frame their approach to the American people as investment over intervention. In this era of more revisionist history, where the United States has been reflecting on its role in overthrowing foreign governments, meddling with other sovereign affairs is almost always an unpopular public decision. Additionally, the United States has been suffering through a massive deficit for decades; a shutdown is almost inevitable every time Congress meets to discuss the budget. So the same question is always posed: why send aid to foreign countries, or launch rockets into space, or act in any way that does not directly serve the American people? First make eggs cheaper and protect the thousands of homeless veterans, and *then* worry about a sovereign foreign state. But Americans have had an almost patriotic disdain towards Russian values for nearly 80 years. The Cold War was fought precisely to impede the growing Russian state, to assert American dominance. Many Americans see the Russian invasion of Ukraine negatively not necessarily because Ukraine is being invaded—we see horrendous conflict in South Sudan, Congo, and even India and do nothing—but because Russia is the antagonist, we feel almost obligated to retaliate by helping their enemy. The enemy of my enemy is my friend.

But none of these approaches are without risk, either. Hungary is certainly alienating much of the E.U., acting against its own organization that has acted so thoroughly and unitarily to sanction Russia. Anything other than inaction or ideally support puts Poland at risk of invasion and further antagonization from Russia. And, of course, Donald Trump is an increasingly popular figure in Russia making him the opposite on the home front, especially after he touted that he

would solve the Ukraine war in 24 hours if he were elected a second time. Even then, these approaches seem logical for each country to taut their own appearance in the world stage.

That said, this issue, like most in the global governance sphere, is still highly complex and cannot be suitably limited to three main reasons or a solely benefit/cost angle. It is therefore prudent to consider some other, more subtle, ideologies in this matter that provide a more holistic approach to why states would or would not act to help Ukraine. One main one is the concern over nuclear weapons should Russia escalate this war. Russia currently has 5,460 nuclear warheads and has no indication of changing its status as a global nuclear power, as they continue using nuclear deterrence to dissuade their enemies (Federation of American Scientists 2025). Countries both with weak defenses and strong nuclear programs (such as the United States) do not want to antagonize another nuclear state, knowing that will lead to millions of innocent deaths and likely an all-out world war.

Additionally, this essay has mostly overlooked the 2014 Russian annexation of Crimea, where Russian forces seized control of the sovereign region in Ukraine, hoping to reassert their hold on power in the region. This led to some sanctions from the U.S. and E.U., but ultimately the event was largely ignored to avoid any further escalation. (The nuclear deterrence strategy seems to have worked out for Russia.) Former U.S. President Barack Obama was often criticized for his seemingly middling stance on Crimea, and history will likely not remember the global leaders at the time well for this inaction against an outright rejection of the right to sovereignty. It is therefore possible that, to avoid being seen as hypocritical, some countries may want to equally back down from this current Ukrainian conflict. But, on the other hand, this may be a reason for action. Undoing past mistakes, ideally if they were committed by a different leader, is a great way to get domestic support especially for a “universally bad” action such as the invasion of Ukraine; support in Israel or Palestine has proven to be much more controversial, for instance. In this same vein, and we do see this with the China-Russia alliance, states that are also trying to reclaim land on a cultural basis (China, Israel, maybe even Kurdistan) would equally hesitate to call out Russia for trying to “reclaim” Ukraine.¹

States are ultimately realists whose international action is heavily dependent on their standing at home, especially in the post-Arab Spring world where injustice is visible everywhere instantly and government inaction or misdeeds are more easily sniffed out by “Internet sleuths.” Hungary does not worry about being invaded by Russia because of its strong economic alliance, lack of antagonism as well as a lack of history as a member state of the U.S.S.R. Poland does not share in this lightheartedness and so its priorities are much different: Ukraine should be protected and aided because, one day, Poland and much of eastern Europe might be in their shoes (Nielsen 2022). Summarily, the internal/domestic angle (protection from being “Ukraine-d” in the future, reliance on oil, strongly rooted capitalist values) is necessary to explain why a state may act hypocritically across different election cycles and events, as they have to acknowledge not only their global alliances but the ability to garner domestic support for an international action. The leader concerns themselves primarily on their next victory in most political settings, and even authoritarian leaders have to find some legitimacy to continue to justify their actions. If not to the people then maybe, hopefully, to themselves.

¹ It’s worthy to note I came up with this entire section on Crimea/nuclear weapons myself, so I might be totally wrong in my interpretation. I thought it would be fun—and it was! ☺

Note: I in-text cited sources in seemingly awkward places because I generated my own ideas while being heavily influenced by these authors. Research papers for the assignment requirements have been bolded for your convenience.

I also had to omit exploring how Trump's first impeachment trial (for interfering in the 2020 presidential election) was influenced by Ukraine and Russia, especially since he allegedly ordered Ukraine to investigate Joe Biden and it seems that Russia interfered in the 2016 presidential elections. Interesting point I did not have the page count for.

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Some links I did not have the time to properly cite ☹ But they were of very minimal relevance to this essay, being mostly news articles.

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